



ALL THAT GLITTER Gold-plated *dwarapalakas* at the Sabarimala shrine; (inset) Unnikrishnan Potti, once a priestly helper and now chief suspect

EKEEPERS LOSE SHINE

priestly bit player at the centre of the intrigue, heats up Kerala

Left Front government, which part-controls TDB, too, finds itself in a soup, with the Opposition Congress and BJP as well as sundry Hindu outfits in the state baying for blood of the Devaswom minister and the TDB president.

'OUTSOURCING' GOLD

The charge? Missing gold from the gold-clad copper sheets that covered the 18th-century *dwarapalaka* (gatekeeper) idols flanking the temple's sanctum sanctorum. On September 9, a special commissioner informed the Kerala High Court that the sheets were transported for repairs to a Chennai-based jewellery outfit, Smart Creations—sans permission and in violation of temple manual rules that say all such work must happen in situ. A probe by the TDB vigilance wing then revealed Smart Creations had also done the 'original' gold plating in 2019, again in Chennai, again mediated by Potti.

The court ordered that the sheets be immediately returned to the temple, which is when they were found to be 4.54 kg lighter, down from 42.8 kg to 38.26 kg. That wasn't the end of it—the exit papers from 2019 handed to Potti by TDB officials clearly list the sheets at least five times as 'copper plates'. This suggests collusion at multiple levels, since it was the board that had done the first gold-plating way back in 1998. Former liquor mogul Vijay Mallya had sponsored most of it, donating 31.25 kg gold and 1,904 kg copper. Of this, experts say, 5 kg gold was used for the cladding of the *dwarapalakas*, the rest for the roof of the sanctum sanctorum and other parts.

Potti, a Tulu Brahmin and now a Bengaluru resident, has emerged as the lead suspect in the case with, as the court put it, "questionable antecedents". He had briefly joined as a lower-grade helper to the Sabarimala chief priest in 2009. Thereafter, he emerged as the main link man for major corporate sponsors and celebrity visits—in short, a major player in the temple's affairs.

Takeaways

- **Probe reveals improprieties, missing gold from gold-plated copper sheets of idols, originally sponsored by Vijay Mallya**
- **Unnikrishnan Potti, a link man for corporate sponsors and celeb visits, is chief suspect**

SETBACK FOR PINARAYI

This isn't the first such scandal at Sabarimala. In 2023, reported irregularities in the number of ornaments adorning the main idol led to the HC ordering a full inventory. Reports say the TDB vigilance wing have found a total of 402 grams of gold missing in the 1998-2019 period. Potti, too, added to the intrigue, saying a set of *dwarapalakas* in the temple's strongroom were missing (officials claimed they were retrieved from his sister's house in Thiruvananthapuram). An e-mail, too, has surfaced, where Potti allegedly asks the TDB president whether he could use 'leftover gold' from the cladding work for a family wedding.

The timing is terrible for the Pinarayi regime: it comes right after the Global Ayyappa Sangamam it held with the TDB to promote Sabarimala—with one eye on the Hindu vote ahead of the 2026 assembly election. That plan now seems to have lost a bit of its shine. ■